Openness in GLAM: Analysing, Reflecting, and Discussing Global Case Studies

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Panel Description:

Openness is now considered a key concept in the Galleries, Libraries, Archives, and Museums (GLAM) sector, shaping current discussions about accessibility, inclusivity, participation, and the democratization of knowledge. In implementing open knowledge principles, cultural heritage institutions are both motivated and sometimes pressured to provide access “to all citizens”. On the one hand, this highlights the potential to bridge gaps between collections, knowledge, policy, technology, and community engagement. On the other hand, this vision is complicated by challenges such as intellectual property restrictions, the ethical limitations of unrestrained openness, legal barriers, costly technological infrastructures, insufficient IT skills, conflicting institutional priorities, and, most recently, questions about the ethics of the commercial exploitation of open data by AI companies.

This panel explores the diverse dimensions of openness within the GLAM sector in a global context, focusing on case studies from museums, libraries, and web archives. It also provides reflections from scholars and practitioners on their practical implementation via sociocultural, historical, and technological lenses. By critically examining selected case studies, the panel seeks to unpack how openness is conceptualized, implemented, and experienced in different institutional contexts. Through qualitative and quantitative analysis, critical reflection, and interdisciplinary approaches, panellists will explore copyright barriers for Australian museums and analyse international examples that suggest potential pathways forward; observe the historical process of implementing openness on the Rijksmuseum (Netherlands) seeing them via the openness of web archives; reveal the paradoxes of open GLAM data that have hindered its promise in the UK; discuss platformization in the cultural sector and biases in historical representation; examine open GLAM addressing colonial approaches building on historical collecting practices; and assess implications of open access challenges and advocates for adopting best practices in the public domain in Portugal. These exemplars of openness in the GLAM sector reveal both the benefits and the challenges of fostering expanded access in the field.

The panel contributes to ongoing debates on digital transformation, accessibility, and sustainability, providing insights into the theoretical and practical implications of the concept of openness for cultural heritage. In line with the DH2025 theme, Building access and accessibility: Open science to all citizens, this panel highlights the critical intersections of openness, accessibility, and digital heritage.

Panellist 1:

Prof. Paul Arthur

Chair in Digital Humanities and Social Sciences, School of Arts and Humanities, Edith Cowan University, Australia

Paper title:

Copyright Barriers for Australian Museums

Abstract:

Fundamental to the open access movement is a call for greater social inclusion through international laws that guarantee individuals the right to participate freely in cultural life; engage in forms of cultural expression; access the arts, humanities and cultural heritage; and acquire knowledge. Although open access to GLAM material is increasingly considered central for a more democratic society, collections often remain siloed across discrete institutions and are largely inaccessible to many. Most cultural institutions are almost wholly funded through public investment

and as such have a duty to provide open access to their work for the broader community wherever possible for public benefit. GLAM materials also face a series of copyright limitations, with current laws ill-adapted to an increasingly open environment in which digital collections can be readily found, modified, mixed, and re-used.

This paper reviews copyright barriers for Australian museums and examines international examples that offer potential ways forward. Recent copyright modernisation reviews offer the museum sector an opportunity to restructure its strategies. As online formats evolve, there is an urgent need to explore how amendments to copyright laws in some countries have allowed more fair and flexible use of cultural artefacts and orphan works. By considering what can be learnt from successful international examples, this paper identifies models the Australian GLAM sector can draw on to advocate for modernisation of the Copyright Amendment Bill. The overall aim is to enhance the usability and value of artefacts, opening new possibilities for education, interpretation, and participation in presenting cultural heritage.

Panellist 2:

Nadezhda Povroznik

Research Associate, Humanities Data Science and Methodology, Technical University of Darmstadt, Germany

Paper title:

A Dual Lens on Openness of the Rijksmuseum: Tracing Historical Processes via Web Archives

Abstract:

The Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam, is recognised as a pioneer in opening up cultural heritage to researchers and to the public (Terras 2015). It has published its digital collections as Linked Open Data (Dijkshoorn et al. 2018), placed these in the public domain, fostered reuse through initiatives like Rijksstudio and Rijksawards, developed data exploration tools (Mensink / van Gemert 2014), and other initiatives. While there is an extensive range of publications on the topic of the Rijksmuseum as an exemplary open institution, the dynamics of this openness remain underexplored. This research aims to reconstruct the process of implementing openness through historical analysis of snapshots of the museum's website preserved in web archives.

The museum's website is a valuable historical resource and a significant instance of born-digital heritage, which requires thorough preservation to provide access to these resources in the future (Schroeder / Brügger 2017). Two interconnected aspects will be addressed during this presentation: the historical process of implementing openness on the Rijksmuseum's website and the openness of web archives, particularly the Internet Archive and the Dutch Web Archive, to explore the websites' history.

The historical process will be traced using qualitative methods to create a timeline and identify milestones, and quantitative methods will be employed to track progress and assess web archives. Comparative analysis will be applied to selected datasets taken yearly: from 2010 and 2011 (before and after the introduction OpenGLAM), 2014 (forwarding dynamics), 2019 and 2022 (before and after the pandemic). Datasets will be assessed regarding URL overlaps, formats, and volumes to evaluate the Internet Archive and the Dutch Web Archive and address a question of openness of the past for historical analysis.

Panellist 3:

Mia Ridge

Digital Curator for Western Heritage Collections, British Library, United Kingdom

Paper title:

The Paradoxes of Open Data in Libraries, Archives and Museums

Abstract:

Museums, libraries and archives have been releasing digital collections records and media as open data for decades. 'Open GLAM' images, metadata and other media have been used for a range of creative, research, commercial and teaching purposes. So why aren't more GLAM collections openly available?

This talk discusses some of the paradoxes of open data in GLAM in the UK, including:

- The lack of robust, sector-wide shared infrastructure providing long-term access to GLAM collections, despite decades of evidence for its value and the difficulties many institutions have in maintaining individual repositories
- The tension between making data open for exploration and re-use (including, scraping by generative AI companies), while respecting copyright and the right of creators to receive income from their writing, art, music, etc.
- Balancing the FAIR principles - making open collections Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Reusable - with the CARE principles for Indigenous Data Governance, to support Indigenous people in "asserting greater control over the application and use of Indigenous data and Indigenous Knowledge for collective benefit" (Global Indigenous Data Alliance, 2018). Operationalizing the CARE principles might require an investment of time in building relationships and trust with Indigenous communities before releasing open data - or perhaps choosing to keep data closed in some ways - that counters the urge for speed.
- The need for financial models to fund collections digitisation that don't rely on individual

users paying for access to collections and the overhead required to provide evidence for the use and impact of open data

While issues like infrastructure and interoperability are technical, the more difficult issues are those linked to organisational culture. In particular, the CARE Principles require an investment in relationships - and true openness to the changes that Indigenous Data Governance might require. The case for open data must be continually remade as financial and intellectual arguments for limiting open data re-emerge.

Panellist 4:

T. Leo Cao, PhD

Lecturer, Department of Media and Journalism, Glasgow Caledonian University, United Kingdom

Paper title:

Editorializing Open Culture through Platform Intervention: The Case of Curationist

Abstract:

This paper uses Curationist as a case study to argue for the necessity of proactive editorialization, grounded in community-driven co-creation, by cultural heritage aggregation platforms. Launched in 2022, Curationist hosts over 4.4 million open access images and metadata aggregated from ten museums worldwide. The platform distinguishes itself by dedicating financial resources not only to support digitization through grant co-applications but also to develop editorial features through residency and fellowship programs that foreground historically underrepresented voices.

Theoretically, the paper is situated within critical platform studies, exploring the sociopolitical implications of platformization in the cultural sector (Poell et al. 2022). While digital platforms often convey an aura of objectivity, they perform inherently political roles in mediating the interaction between cultural institutions and the public (Boyd / Crawford 2012). In an increasingly platform-centered media ecology dominated by algorithmic manipulation that conditions the visibility of social memories (Gillespie 2014), the cultural sector continues to value editorial practices that emphasize institutional authority and interpretive expertise. How does Curationist as an emerging platform both reflect and challenge these dynamics?

Methodologically, the paper combines computational content analysis (i.e., topic modeling) of the editorial features (N=76) on Curationist with in-depth interviews with fellows, critics, and staff members involved in the creation of these essays and exhibitions. This is complemented by discursive interface analysis (Stanfill 2015) of the platform's various affordances and critical discourse analysis of the initiative's annual reports. The findings offer a situated understanding of how content aggregation platforms can actively address biases in historical representation while fostering the contextualized interpretation and use of open access cultural collections.

Panellist 5:

Samantha Callaghan

Research Software Analyst, King's Digital Lab, King's College London, United Kingdom

Paper title:

Is Open GLAM Continuing Extractive Colonial approaches building on Historical Collecting Practices?

Abstract:

The formation of European and settler colonial state collecting institutions is heavily influenced by historical collecting practices of objects and knowledges from Indigenous peoples across the world. These colonial and extractive mindsets created huge collections with poor description data focused on provenance. Imperial and colonial audiences accrued value from these collections.

In current contexts, control through the mechanism of ownership or holding often means that decisions around Open GLAM, in relation to Indigenous materials and data, can be a continuation of these practices.

The recognition of the importance of Indigenous Data Sovereignty (IDSov) as well as the need to define principles has led to the formation of a number of IDSov groups including Te Mana Raraunga, The First Nations Information Governance Centre, and GIDA. They have defined principles of IDSov including CARE and OCAP. This rising movement and promotion of IDSov and Indigenous Data Governance demand that holding institutions actively engage and respect the principles that they define.

In Aotearoa (New Zealand), IDSov principles underpin the Māori Indigenous Data Governance model created for use in the public service. In a European context, a Response to the Sarr-Savoy Report by Pavis and Wallace, is an exercise in recognising and promoting where control of cultural heritage should lie.

In the context of GLAM institutions holding Indigenous material and data, the question is, "where should the benefit lie?" The Te Mana Raraunga charter addresses this by stating, "Māori Data Sovereignty supports tribal sovereignty and the realization of Māori and Iwi aspirations."

Panellist 6:

Luis Ramos Pinto

Digital Heritage professional, Open Access Advocate, Acesso Cultura, Portugal

Paper Title:

Unlocking Portugal's Museum Collections: Navigating Challenges and Contradictions in Access and Reuse

Abstract:

Accessing Portugal's national museum collections online is a complex and contradictory experience. Researchers, educators, and cultural enthusiasts often encounter conflicting messages about rights and usage. A prime example is the Saint Vincent Panels, a Renaissance masterpiece in the Public Domain. While available openly through platforms like Europeana.eu and Wikimedia Commons, the Museus e Monumentos de Portugal E.P. (the entity responsible for managing Portugal's national museums) enforces restrictive copyright terms on its proprietary image database, MatrizPix.

Under these terms, users face licensing fees, mandatory attribution, and prohibitions on image sharing or modification, even for Public Domain works. Such restrictions hinder the inclusion of Portugal's cultural heritage in open-access platforms, contrasting with the open policies of the National Library of Portugal, also under the Ministry of Culture.

This paper explores the implications of these challenges and advocates for adopting best practices in Public Domain recognition and open access. By aligning with international standards, Portugal can enhance the visibility and usability of its museum collections, fostering research and creativity.

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